

STAGE THIRTEEN • TEAMWORK & COLLABORATION

FIRSTS

ICEBREAKERS / OPENERS

Short, stage-themed warm-ups tied to what each session actually covers

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Icebreakers / Openers

Stage Thirteen • Teamwork & Collaboration

PURPOSE

Stage Thirteen runs across three sessions — Team Foundations, Working Together in Practice, and Navigating Difficulty & Closing Out — each gets one icebreaker below, built directly from that session's actual content.

Because this stage is fundamentally about collaboration itself, several of these openers are structured as small, live collaborative exercises rather than purely verbal warm-ups — they let participants feel a version of the session's core lesson (default versus deliberate teams, the challenge of async writing, the value of real closure) in miniature before it's named explicitly.

Each includes the instructions to read to the group, a time estimate, and a short note on why it's specifically the right opener for what comes next.

Three Openers, One Per Session

SESSION 1

The Default Team

TIME: 10 min

1. Ask participants to think of the last team or group they joined — did they choose it deliberately, or did it just happen to them (assigned seating, random group, whoever was free)?
2. Quick show of hands: how many were genuinely deliberate versus default?
3. In pairs, share one thing that might have gone differently if that team had been formed around genuine, confirmed alignment from the start.

WHY THIS WORKS

This surfaces, before any formal teaching, the exact distinction FIRST Q1 is built on — that most teams form by default, and deliberate alignment is the thing most groups skip.

SESSION 2

The Silent Update

TIME: 8 min

1. Pair participants up. Partner A writes a two-sentence status update about a real (or invented, if nothing real is available) task, without saying anything out loud.
2. Partner B reads only the written update — no clarifying questions allowed — and tries to summarize what's actually going on.
3. Compare: did Partner B's summary match what Partner A actually meant?

WHY THIS WORKS

This is a fast, concrete taste of the exact challenge behind FIRST Q17 (Asynchronous Collaboration) — writing something genuinely self-contained is harder than it sounds until you try it.

SESSION 3

Best Team, Worst Ending

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask the group: “think of a team experience that started strong but ended without any real closure — no celebration, no retrospective, just... over.”
2. Quick round-robin, one word or phrase describing how that lack of closure felt.
3. Facilitator notes the pattern: how many experiences shared that same “just fizzled out” quality?

WHY THIS WORKS

This makes visible, in the group's own experience, exactly the gap FIRSTS Q26–Q29 are designed to close — most teams never pause to genuinely celebrate or reflect, and today's session gives

language and structure for both.